AUSTRIAN FLANDERS

In the Austrian Netherlands I found the prisons in general clean; and no sickness prevailing in any one of them: and yet few of the prisons have a court: in most of them every prisoner is confined to his room. In some places, as at Antwerp, etc., the allowance to criminals is scanty; a pound and a half of bread a day, and a pound of butter a week: but the deficiency is fully made up by supplies from the monasteries, etc. Debtors very few: they are alimented by their creditors.

ANTWERP. In the prison at Antwerp there are two rooms for citizens; and upstairs there is a cage, about six feet and a half square, into which criminals are put before the torture. A criminal, while he suffers the torture, is clothed in a long shirt, has his eyes bound, and a physician and surgeon attend him: and when a confession is forced from him, and wine has been given him, he is required to sign his confession; and about forty-eight hours afterwards he is executed.

In a small dungeon is a stone seat like some I have seen in old prison towers, in which it is said that formerly prisoners were suffocated by brimstone, when their families wished to avoid the disgrace of a public execution. No person here remembers an instance of this kind; but about thirty years ago there was a private execution in the prison. In this prison in 1778 there were only two prisoners. In November 1781 there were three prisoners for debt; their allowance was three halfpence a day.

The clergy have a prison in this city which is an old tower, three stories high, to which persons who come under their cognisance for adultery, incest, etc., are committed.

15 June, 1783, there was not one prisoner in this city.

In 1778 here was a house of correction. The river ran under it; on one side were the keeper's apartments; on the other, the warehouse and the room for the magistrates. On three sides of a paved court there were thirteen cells for the men, and over them were the rooms for the women. On one side of the court were the young women who were put in by their parents or relations; and on the other, the criminals. All the men were employed in spinning cotton; so were some of the women, and the rest in making lace. A pound of cotton at a time was delivered to each; for spinning which, thirteen sous [1] were paid.

[1] A sou is about a halfpenny.

I found, by the books, that at first coming, some did not earn more than seven or eight sous in a week, but soon after they earned from twelve to fourteen. Rye bread (to the value of half a stiver [1] each meal) and water, was their allowance; and whatever they had more than this, they were required to pay for out of their earnings. They were obliged to put on clean linen every week, towards washing which each paid a sou. The stoves were heated twice a day, and candles and lamps were provided, at the expense of the magistrates.

There were three rooms for the ungovernable. One of them (the penitentiary room) had a floor made of pieces of wood laid edgeways four inches asunder. The prisoner was chained in the middle of this floor, so that he could move but a few steps; and being allowed no shoes or stockings, whether he stood or lay down, he must have been in a very uneasy posture. This room therefore was dreaded by the prisoners. The other rooms were abodes so dark and solitary, as to be almost equally dreadful.

The men were never suffered to go out, except on Sundays and other holy days, when they went to the chapel, in which they had seats below. The women sat in a gallery, with a lattice of wood before them. Here, and also in the prison, a table of regulations was hung up, which was read in public by the chaplain, the first Sunday after the entrance of every prisoner. These regulations consisted of thirty-six articles, from which I have taken the following extracts:

> The prisoners must be submissive to the keeper and to his wife; and if they think themselves injured, must complain to the regents.—The times fixed for rising are, at half after six in the morning from 1 December to 15 February, and all the rest of the year at five, or half after five; but on Sundays and holy days at six.—The times of meals are fixed at seven, twelve, and seven. The prisoners are allowed, at their own expense, at breakfast a pint of tea; and at dinner soup or broth, or a pint of tea or small beer, and at supper the same quantity of tea or beer; and on Sundays and other holy days a certain quantity of boiled meat: and every week a pound of butter, and fruit to the value of half a stiver.—Every day the keeper is obliged to prepare two sorts of soup or broth, and at seven in the morning to give the prisoners their choice of either sort, or none.—After service on Sundays, the men are permitted to walk in the court, and the women in the gallery half an hour, under the inspection of the keeper and officers.—They forfeit half a stiver, every time they curse or swear, or make a disturbance in the chapel; and also every time they are not up in half an hour after they are awakened by the keeper, and for every hour they sleep longer.—If they persist

[1] A stiver is about a penny.